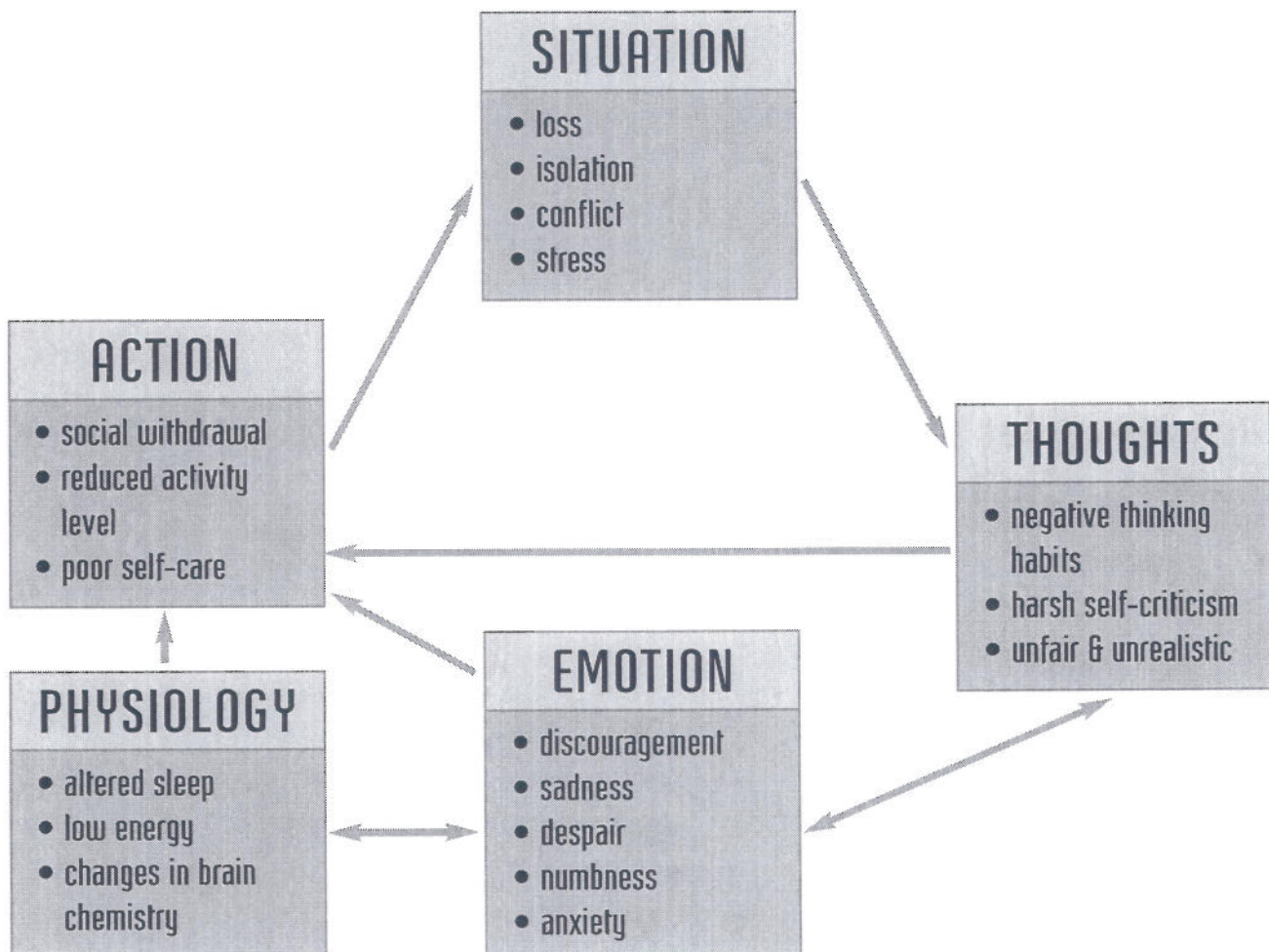


WHAT CAUSES DEPRESSION?

People become depressed for a wide variety of reasons.

Research has identified a number of factors associated with causing and continuing the depressed state. The diagram below shows the five major factors: situation; thoughts; emotion; physiology; and action. Each of

these areas of your life can play a role in the development of depression, and depression itself can have an impact on all of them. On the following pages we consider each of these factors in more detail.

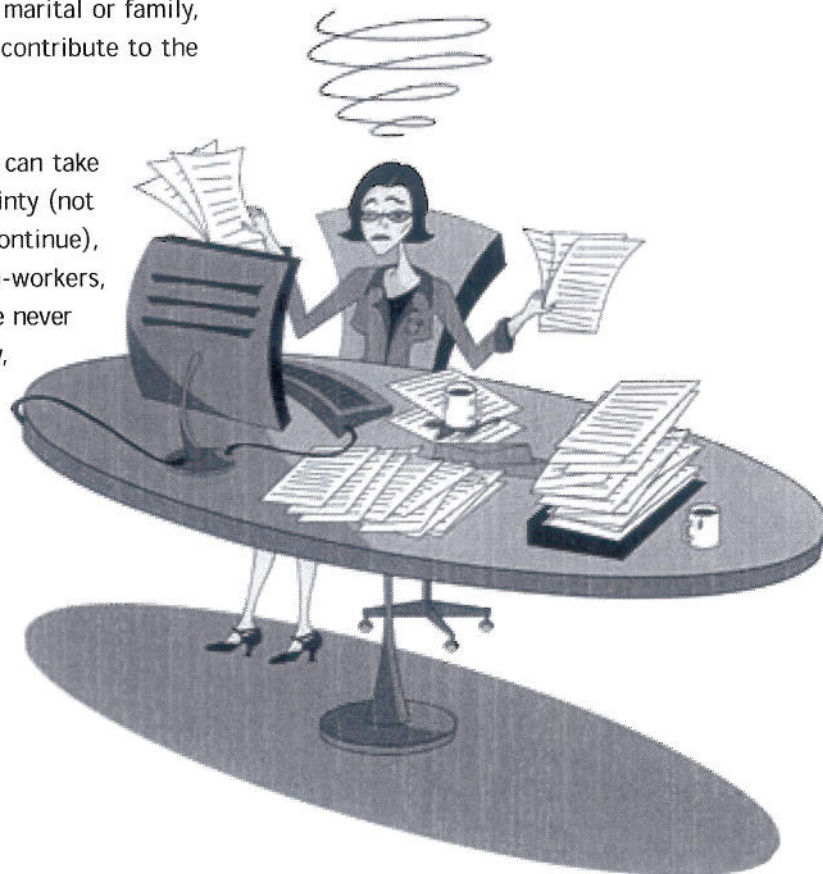


Situation

Depression is often triggered by very stressful life situations. If your attempts to cope with these situations by improving or accepting them have not been successful, you may begin to feel overwhelmed and hopeless. Then the risk of a depressive episode increases. Some situations that can be associated with depression include:

- **Major life events, particularly involving loss.** Events such as the death of a loved one, moving, divorce, financial setbacks, or job loss are major disruptions in one's life.
- **Lack of contact with other people.** Social isolation is a significant risk factor for depression.
- **Relationship conflict.** Times of conflict in personal relationships, whether marital or family, are extremely stressful and can contribute to the onset of depression.
- **Stress related to your job.** This can take the form of employment uncertainty (not knowing whether your job will continue), friction with supervisors and co-workers, or overwork (human beings were never designed to work 16 hours a day, either in an occupation or around home).
- **Stress related to your physical health.** This is especially true for health problems that are chronic, cause a lot of pain or disability, and only get partly better with treatment. Some physical illnesses or their treatments can trigger depression by their effects on the body. For example, hypothyroidism (a condition in which the thyroid gland secretes too little thyroid hormone) is often associated with fatigue and depression.

That doesn't mean people only get depressed when things are going badly. Some people get depressed when their life has been going smoothly: depression just seems to come out of nowhere! Antidepressant skills like the ones taught in this book are just as useful for these people.



WHAT CAUSES DEPRESSION?

Thoughts

Each of us is affected differently by outside events, depending on how we think about those events. Imagine two people walking into a party. One person is naturally outgoing, anticipates enjoying herself a great deal, and sees the group of partygoers as friendly and receptive. The other dreads social gatherings,

anticipates feeling miserable, and sees the other people as judgmental and rejecting. Each person's thoughts determine how the event is experienced. Research evidence has shown that depressed individuals often have distorted ways of thinking about the world that can trigger or worsen the experience of depression.



Distorted ways of thinking

Unrealistic, negative thoughts about the situation.

You see the situation in an unrealistically pessimistic way, emphasizing its negative or threatening aspects and ignoring more positive or promising aspects.

Unfair, negative thoughts about yourself.

You think about yourself in a very critical fashion, judging yourself in a harsh and unfair manner.

Unrealistic, negative thoughts about the future.

You anticipate a future that is bleak and disappointing, exaggerating the likelihood of very negative outcomes.

Taken together, we call this the *Negative Triad*: thinking in an unfair and unrealistic, negative way about your current situation, yourself, and your future.

These ways of thinking often start in childhood. Some people grew up in families where only negative and critical comments were made. In other families, children were discouraged from saying positive things about themselves and rewarded for being self-critical. Whether these negative thinking styles are caused by the depression or started in childhood, they have enormous influence on your experience of the world.

Not surprisingly, these ways of thinking about the world increase the negative impact of difficult life situations and predispose people to emotional pain. A person with depressive thinking can become discouraged or hopeless even when things are going well.

Emotion

Depression often begins with feelings of discouragement and sadness after unsuccessful attempts to deal with a difficult life situation. However, as the depression continues, these feelings of unhappiness give way to more severe and painful kinds of emotional experience. The depressed individual is overcome by a sense of despair, a pervasive mood of hopeless misery. A feeling of intense anxiety (physical tension, worry, and a sense of impending doom) often accompanies these depressed feelings.

Some depressed people experience a general sense of *emotional numbness*, an inability to feel anything. It is as though the psychological pain has become so intense that your mind simply switches off your emotions, like a circuit breaker.

Remember that depressed people interpret the world in an unrealistically pessimistic way and judge themselves in a harsh and unfair manner. The emotions they feel are based in large part on this negative way of interpreting their lives. If their thoughts about the world are unrealistic and negative, then their emotions will also be unrealistic and negative.

It may be hard to think about emotions as unrealistic. But imagine a person who firmly believes that airplane travel is extremely dangerous and that planes are falling out of the sky frequently. That person will feel very frightened when flying. This fear, however, is based on a false belief about airplane safety and is, therefore, unrealistic and inappropriate to the situation. Similarly, depressed individuals often have beliefs about the world and themselves that are unrealistic and lead to unrealistic, negative emotions.

Physiology

Depression is accompanied by a variety of physical symptoms. One of the most powerful physical changes accompanying depression is impaired sleep. Usually, this involves an inability to get enough sleep, whether because the person has difficulty falling asleep, repeatedly wakes during the night, or awakens much too early. Sometimes the person may sleep too much, caused by a desire simply to hide away in sleep or a fatigue so pervasive that there never seems to be enough sleep. When sleep is “non-restorative” – that is, the person does not awake feeling refreshed and rested – it becomes harder to face the day and deal with problems. Depressed people often feel that they lack energy and are exhausted by everyday activities.

One theory of depression is that it is caused by changes in brain function, a “chemical imbalance”. There is research showing that, for some depressed people, certain neurochemicals in the brain are less active. It is unclear, however, whether these changes in brain chemistry commonly cause depression. All we know is that depression is often associated with changes in brain chemistry.

The physiological changes of depression make it harder to cope with life problems or even to follow the steps of a depression management program like this one. Antidepressant medication can often be quite helpful in restoring sleep and regaining your sense of physical energy. It can allow you to actively learn and try out the new skills needed to overcome depression.

Action

Depression usually has a significant impact on a person's behaviour. Here are some of the main areas affected:

Not doing rewarding activities.

Hobbies, crafts, sports, reading, and travel may all suffer. Depressed people often feel too tired or unmotivated to pursue these activities, and the less they participate in them, the less they feel able to do so. Most depressed people suffer from *anhedonia*, reduced ability to have fun or get enjoyment from things. Why would you go to the movies, engage in hobbies, or do the things you used to enjoy if you didn't think you would enjoy them? Inactivity becomes a habit. As a result, the depressed person no longer receives the personal satisfaction provided by these activities, further contributing to the sense of discouragement.

Not taking care of yourself.

Activities designed to maintain one's body and appearance are frequently neglected. Depressed individuals may take less care in personal grooming or dress than usual. In addition, exercise is often reduced, whether this involves formal fitness activities such as jogging or simply walking around the neighbourhood. Eliminating exercise contributes to depression by removing a powerful source of physical well-being and increased self-esteem. As well, the depressed person often has disrupted eating habits, whether this means inadequate intake ("forgetting to eat") related to a lack of appetite, or overeating as a form of self comfort.

WHAT CAUSES DEPRESSION?

Not doing small duties.

A depressed person often neglects or procrastinates doing small, necessary duties, like running errands, taking out the garbage, cleaning house, or caring for the garden. Failing to complete these chores adds to the depressed person's sense of inadequacy and lack of control over life. It also creates friction with others and places further stress on relationships.

Withdrawing from family and friends.

Social invitations are refused, phone calls are ignored, and habitual get-togethers with family or friends somehow just don't happen. Social isolation is a strong contributor to depressed mood, taking you away from the warmth and sense of connection to others, basic to all of us. Depressed people often believe that others have no interest in their company, given how miserable or emotionally flat they are feeling.



Building Happiness

Promotions, new relationships, and even winning the lottery will give you only a temporary boost in happiness. Each person has a baseline level of happiness that they quickly return to. Sustained happiness takes work. Listed below are exercises that, when practiced frequently, can build genuine and lasting happiness.

Gratitudes: Write down three things for which you are grateful every day. Don't worry if they seem simple or mundane—just get something down on paper. Writing gratitudes will help you identify positive aspects of even the worst days.

Acts of kindness: Make a conscious effort to do something nice for no reason other than to help. You might be surprised how a simple act of kindness can turn around the day for both you and the kindness recipient.

Exercise: The positive effects of exercise are astounding. Physically active people have increased energy, superior immune systems, and a frequent sense of accomplishment. Exercise can reduce insomnia, stimulate brain growth, and even act as an anti-depressant. If jogging or lifting weights seems like too much, don't be afraid to start with a 30 minute walk or a slow bike ride.

Meditation: Research has linked meditation with reduced anxiety and more positive emotions. Those who meditate regularly may even permanently restructure their brains to create sustained happiness.

Positive journaling: Take some time to write about positive events in your life. Write about a fun day spent with friends, a good movie, or an activity you enjoyed. Positive journaling will get you into the habit of focusing on the positive.

Fostering relationships: Strong social connections are thought to be one of the most powerful influences on our mood. Those who are dedicated to spending time with friends and family show the highest levels of happiness. If you can't see your loved ones every day you can still send an email or make a phone call. If it feels like you *never* see your loved ones, schedule time that can be dedicated to them.

Positive Traits

Kind	Insightful	Sensitive
Intelligent	Funny	Organized
Hardworking	Patient	Selfless
Loyal	Realistic	Practical
Attractive	Honest	Mature
Down-to-Earth	Generous	Focused
Goofy	Modest	Courteous
Creative	Serious	Grateful
Accepting	Independent	Open-Minded
Strong	Trusting	Positive
Friendly	Resilient	Responsible
Flexible	Cheerful	Cooperative
Nurturing	Self-Directed	Frugal
Thoughtful	Reliable	Tolerant
Confident	Relaxed	Innovative
Optimistic	Listener	Balanced
Respectful	Brave	
Determined	Decisive	
Skilled	Enthusiastic	
Helpful	Forgiving	
Motivated	Humble	

About Me

Sentence Completion



I was really happy when... _____



Something that my friends like about me is... _____



I'm proud of... _____



My family was happy when I... _____



In school, I'm good at... _____



Something that makes me unique is... _____

MY COMPLIMENTS...TO MYSELF

I AM
GOOD
AT...



I FEEL
GOOD
WHEN I...

I AM A
GOOD FRIEND
BECAUSE...



MOST PEOPLE
REALLY LIKE MY...

I AM A
GOOD PERSON
BECAUSE...

I AM
PROUD
OF...

I KNOW I AM
LOVED BECAUSE...



My Strengths and Qualities

Things I am good at:

1

2

3

Compliments I have received:

1

2

3

What I like about my appearance:

1

2

3

Challenges I have overcome:

1

2

3

I've helped others by:

1

2

3

Things that make me unique:

1

2

3

What I value the most:

1

2

3

Times I've made others happy:

1

2

3

Positive Experiences

Write briefly about times when you have displayed each of the following qualities.

❖ **Courage**

❖ **Kindness**

❖ **Selflessness**

❖ **Love**

❖ **Sacrifice**

❖ **Wisdom**

❖ **Happiness**

❖ **Determination**

Positive Journal

Every day brings a combination of good and bad experiences. Unfortunately, the human brain tends to focus more heavily on the bad experiences, while forgetting or discounting the good experiences. For example, we're more likely to remember one awkward social interaction over hundreds of normal interactions.

Making a point to recognize positive experiences—no matter how small—can help to improve mood. Practice by recording three positive events at the end of each day.

Monday
1
2
3

Tuesday
1
2
3

Wednesday
1
2
3

Positive Journal

Thursday
1
2
3

Friday
1
2
3

Saturday
1
2
3

Sunday
1
2
3

Why I'm Grateful



I am grateful for my family because... _____



Something good that happened this week... _____



I am grateful for my friendship with... _____ because... _____



I am grateful for who I am because... _____



Something silly that I am grateful for... _____



Something else I am grateful for... _____

Coping Skills

Below are some options for general coping. Remember to incorporate other coping skills that you have used or have previously found to be helpful.

Self Soothing

Breathing:

Take deep breaths from the diaphragm or stomach. Breathe in then, when you breathe out; very slowly release your breath out.

Exercise:

Change your focus, get your body moving

Music:

Use a relaxing or lively tune or music that inspires you. Consider dancing.

Relax your body:

Progressive muscle relaxation. Download guided relaxation. Take a bath or shower. Do yoga.

Comfort Item:

Hold onto or wrap yourself in something comforting – a blanket, jacket, scarf, stuffed animal – anything that helps you feel more comfortable.

Imagery:

Look at and direct your attention towards picture or photograph of a beautiful and calming scene (i.e., beach, mountains).

Visualization:

Visualize a place you love, either that you have been at, or that you enjoy imagining yourself to be there. Describe it paying attention to using all five senses (e.g., the beach: what it looks like, how the sand feels, what it sounds like: wind and waves, salt water smell).

Do Something Positive

Do One Positive Thing.

Do something positive for yourself or for someone else. Every day is an opportunity to do something to move you towards your goals or towards being more positive.

Socialize:

Call someone and talk about something pleasant, encourage them to talk about something pleasant, plan to do something pleasant,...

Call someone and vent about what is bothering you – but keep it time-limited.

Entertain yourself:

Computer game, crossword, cards, jigsaw, cook, read books, magazines, etc, do crafts, sudoku.....

List your achievements

What have you done that was challenging for you, what have you put effort into, what have people said you do well....

Prayer

Use whatever prayers, rituals, spiritually inspiring readings, music or activities that get you in touch with something bigger than yourself.

Problem Solving

Is there something you can do towards solving the problem?

Dealing with your thoughts and assumptions

Self-statements/Cognitive Coping:

What can you say to yourself to help you feel better?

Examples include, "I'm safe now; he's not here; It's not my fault. I can get through this."

You already survived your past.

Use your skills to identify the thoughts bothering you and see if you can identify an alternative true way to think about what is happening.

Redirect Unhelpful Thoughts:

Notice if you have a lot of self-critical or otherwise discouraging thoughts. Push these away and identify something positive you can do.

What would your mentor say?

Whom do you admire? What do you imagine they would say to encourage you?

Reality Check:

Is there something I need to do about this right now?

Is there something I could do about this right now?

Is there another way to think about this?

Radical Acceptance

Lifeline – is there someone else I can talk to about my options?

Distracting

Focus on your Senses Right now

Identify something you see, something you hear, something you smell, something you touch. While doing this stay mindfully focused on just your senses in the moment. Describe what you are sensing. Look at something specific. Smell something strong (scented lotion, candle, oil, spices). Touch different textures – not just with your hands – use your face, your feet, etc. Taste something minty or strong flavored, and/or brush your teeth.

Mindful Eating:

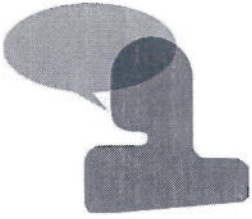
Examine food (e.g., 1 raisin), watch hand move towards your mouth, take a moment to smell it, how body reacting to smell (e.g., mouth watering), how is food positioned in mouth? Begin chewing slowly, what tastes experiencing? When you swallow, feel muscles contract as you push food to your stomach, be aware of sensations (Can eat with non-dominant hand to increase awkwardness and increase likelihood you'll have to pay attention).

Mindful Walking:

Walk slowly and carefully feeling your feet connect at each point on the floor. Without controlling breath too much, you can try pairing walking and breathing so that 1 foot touches the ground at each *in* and *out* breath. See how many steps seem natural to take during each inhalation and exhalation. Direct all attention towards the sensations of walking: your feet and lower legs. Which part touches the ground first? Pay attention to how your weight shifts from one foot to the other. What are the feelings in your knees as they bend? What is the texture of the ground (hard, soft, cracks, stones)? What are differences in walking on different surfaces?

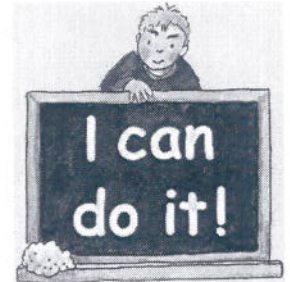
Your Ideas:

Positive Self- talk / Coping Thoughts Worksheet



Positive statements encourage us and help us cope through distressing times. We can say these encouraging words to ourselves, and be our own personal coach. We have all survived some very distressing times, and we can use those experiences to encourage us through current difficulties. Examples of coping thoughts might be:

- Stop, and breathe, I can do this
- This will pass
- I can be anxious/angry/sad and still deal with this
- I have done this before, and I can do it again
- This feels bad, it's a normal body reaction – it will pass
- This feels bad, and feelings are very often wrong
- These are just feelings, they will go away
- This won't last forever
- Short term pain for long term gain
- I can feel bad and still choose to take a new and healthy direction
- I don't need to rush, I can take things slowly
- I have survived before, I will survive now
- I feel this way because of my past experiences, but I am safe right now
- It's okay to feel this way, it's a normal reaction
- Right now, I am not in danger. Right now, I'm safe
- My mind is not always my friend
- Thoughts are just thoughts – they're not necessarily true or factual
- This is difficult and uncomfortable, but it's only temporary
- I can use my coping skills and get through this
- I can learn from this and it will be easier next time
- Keep calm and carry on



Yes!

Write down a coping thought or positive statement for each difficult or distressing situation – something you can tell yourself that will help you get through. Write them down on a piece of card and carry it in your pocket or handbag to help remind you.

Difficult or distressing situation	Coping thought / Positive statement

How To Create A Mantra

We all get overwhelmed sometimes, and when we think too much about our anxieties about the future we prevent ourselves from taking care of our own present moment. When you begin to feel overwhelmed or anxious about the future, remind yourself of your mantra.

Follow the steps below to create your own mantra:

Reflect

Take 20-45 minutes reflecting on how you feel, what is going on around you, and where your anxiety is coming from. Develop a deep understanding of the issue. Use the space below to journal your key notes for developing your mantra.

Consider

It can be rough at times in life, and it can be easy to forget those lessons we have learned growing up that help us have confidence in our future and ourselves. What do you know about yourself and the world around you that will help bring you confidence in your abilities to overcome challenges?

Create

It is time to create your mantra. Create a mantra, or saying, to remind yourself of what you need to remember when you feel anxious, upset or overwhelmed. It will need to be a mantra that you can easily remember and recall, so try to keep it to one short sentence.

For example:

"I am stronger than my anxiety."

"I will get through this."

"This too, shall pass."

MY SELF-CARE PLAN



Everyone has bad days. What counts is how we deal with those downer days. Will you perpetuate the negative spiral, or will you pick yourself back up again?

This worksheet is a tool kit for your worst days. Answer the questions now, and when you start feeling down, come back to these prompts to start feeling like yourself again.

1. List 10 things you are grateful for in life:

2. Describe the perfect day of your dreams:

3. What one, realistic thing could you do for yourself today that captures the essence of your fantasy day?

4. What is the best compliment you've ever received? What has someone said to you that always makes you smile?

5. What was your favorite thing to do as a kid? How could you recreate that activity as an adult?

Negative Thinking Traps

- **Black & White / All-or-Nothing / Dichotomous thinking**
 - Things are good or bad, safe or dangerous. No middle ground.
 - Things are perfect or they are a total failure, nothing in between
- **Focusing on the Negatives / Negative Filter**
 - Focusing in on the negative, scary, or unfair things, ignoring anything good.
- **Overgeneralization**
 - An "F" on one assignment means you'll never succeed in anything.
 - One bad interaction and you decide someone is a jerk. Something bad in one area means something about all areas; something tough about right now means your whole future will be tough; etc.
- **Personalization**
 - Everything is about you. Your friend looks upset, you assume it must be your fault. Your Father doesn't agree with you, you assume he's trying to make you mad.
- **Catastrophizing**
 - Your friend doesn't call when he says he will. You think the friendship must be over.
 - You forget to turn in an assignment, you think you're going to flunk out of high school, never get into the college you want.
- **Perfectionism / Setting Unrealistic Expectations**
 - Asking yourself to be perfect, not allowing yourself to make mistakes.
 - This makes you feel like a failure when you do make mistakes (which is only human), and discourages you from trying anything new, making it hard to get a sense of achievement and preventing you from doing things you might enjoy.
- **Mind Reading**
 - Acting like you can tell what people are thinking about you. Getting very negative or angry when often it is only your imagination. Sometimes you might be right, but most of the time you got worried or upset over a situation that never really existed.
- **Minimizing/Discounting**
 - You maximize your failures and minimize your successes. You discount positive events and allow negative events to count more.
 - Even though I hit a home run earlier in the game, I let my team down when I struck out later in the game.
- **Blaming**
 - You focus on the other person as the source of the problem, when you may have had some part in it. You expect the other person to change or fix things when there are things you could do.



Negative Self-Talk

Changing Your Mind

Positive (or negative) self-talk can be very powerful. If you go into an exam thinking “I can do this. I’m totally prepared. I’m going to ace this thing!” you’re far more likely to be successful than if you go in worrying “I’m not ready for this. I’m going to fail!” In addition to affecting your academic performance, self-talk influences your athletic performance, your ability to overcome personal crises, and your eating and physical activity behaviors.

Some tips:

1. Listen to your thoughts.
2. Decide if your thoughts help or hurt your progress.
3. STOP your negative thoughts.
4. Re-word your negative thoughts to make them into positive messages. Check out the guidelines and examples below:

Consider these guidelines...

- Think about successful changes you’ve already made. Imagine good results with changes you plan on making.
- Say what you are doing now. Use the present tense.
- Make it as positive as you can. Be specific.
- Forget what should be.
- Make it personal with special meaning to you. Contradict an old negative message you’ve been saying far too long.

Examples:

Negative Thoughts	Positive Thoughts
Examples:	
I can’t eat any chocolate! It’s so fattening!	I can have a couple of pieces of chocolate when I feel like having some. We all need some fat in our diet. Eating some fat doesn’t mean I will become fat.
I didn’t lose a pound this week. I’m never going to lose weight.	Weight loss may be slow, but this time it will stay off.
I ate half a bag of chips. It’s hopeless; I’m always going to be an overeater.	I usually polish off a whole bag of chips at one time. I’m really beginning to make progress.
I must exercise every day or I’ll never lose weight and be healthy.	Rest is also important for health. If I exercise too much, I could get injured and ultimately exercise less often.
I’m a pound heavier today. My day is ruined!	It’s normal for weight to fluctuate one or two pounds a day due to fluid shifts. It doesn’t mean I’ve gained a pound of fat.
I would eat healthier if the food in the dining halls weren’t so greasy.	There are several low fat choices in the dining halls. I can make turkey sandwiches for lunch, and the salad bar is stocked with lots of healthy vegetables and even low calorie dressings.
If I eat too much, I have to do something to get rid of it or else I’ll get fat!	It’s normal to sometimes eat more than I really need. But, it takes days of overeating to gain weight. I’ll just go back to my normal eating and exercise routine and everything will be fine.
If I ask for “no oil,” people will make fun of my efforts to lose weight.	Lots of people make low fat requests at restaurants, especially in L.A. No one will think anything of it.
That girl is thinner than me. I’ve got to lose weight!	I work-out regularly and have a lean, muscular body. Weight doesn’t say anything about body composition, health, or beauty. I’m the best I can be.

5. Repeat it many times a day. (i.e. While you brush your teeth, as you wait in the lunch line, while sitting in class, just before you go to sleep at night).
6. Write, print, or type them on a piece of paper. Post them on a mirror, on your notebook, on your car dashboard--any place you’ll see it often.

surviving troubling times

Describe the worst thing that ever happened to you.

What has helped you to survive through such a difficult experience?

What else could help you to cope with this experience? Are there any skills or techniques that you have learned that have helped you to deal with it? Explain.

[illegible]

How has this experience affected you and how will you try to make things better for yourself?

Looking Back

When we look back at our lives, it's easy to gloss over all the things that have gone well. It's natural for many of us to downplay our accomplishments, and instead focus on mistakes. In this exercise, you will be asked to look back, with a focus on all the things that went right.

Choose a timeframe to reflect on. For example, use a time period (e.g. "past year"), or a life event (e.g. "since starting my new job").

Timeframe:

List your accomplishments from this timeframe, even if they seem minor.

Describe a great day from this timeframe. What made this day special?

How have you grown, or what lessons did you learn, during this timeframe?

What are you grateful for from this timeframe? Try to list at least three examples.

What was a challenge that you overcame during this timeframe?

Looking Forward

There's evidence that imagining our "best possible self" can help to improve optimism, and motivation for change. In this exercise, you'll be asked to look forward, and imagine an ideal future for yourself.

Choose a timeframe to think about. For example, use a time period (e.g. "next month"), or a life event (e.g. "during college").

Timeframe:

What would you like to achieve during this timeframe?

What are you looking forward to during this timeframe? Try to list at least three examples.

What relationships would you like to strengthen during this timeframe?

What can you do to help others during this timeframe?

Ideally, how will your life be different at the end of this timeframe? Give specifics.

Protective Factors



Protective factors are things that contribute to mental health, and allow a person to be resilient in the face of challenges. Someone with a lot of protective factors—such as strong relationships and healthy coping skills—will be better equipped to overcome life's obstacles.

Many protective factors are out of your control. For example, genetics, the neighborhood where you grew up, and family cannot be changed. However, plenty of factors can be controlled. You choose the people in your life, how to cope with problems, and how you'll spend each day.

By focusing on what you can control, and building upon those protective factors, you will improve your ability to cope with many of life's challenges.



My Protective Factors

Instructions: Review each of the following protective factors, and mark the scales to indicate how well you are performing in each area.

Social Support

- ability to talk about problems
- people to ask for practical help (e.g. a ride if car breaks down)
- feelings of love, intimacy, or friendship



Coping Skills

- ability to manage uncomfortable emotions in a healthy way
- awareness of one's own emotions, and recognition of how they influence behavior



Physical Health

- adequate exercise or physical activity
- a balanced and healthy diet
- medical compliance (e.g. taking medications as prescribed)



Sense of Purpose

- meaningful involvement in work, education, or other roles (e.g. parenting)
- understanding of personal values, and living in accordance with those values



Self-Esteem

- belief that one's self has value
- acceptance of personal flaws, weaknesses, or mistakes
- belief in ability to overcome challenges



Healthy Thinking

- *does not* ruminate on mistakes, personal flaws, or problems
- ability to recognize personal strengths and weaknesses rationally



Protective Factors

Instructions: Refer to the protective factors on the previous page to answer the following questions.

Which protective factor has been the most valuable to you during difficult times?

--

Specifically, how have you used this protective factor to your advantage in the past?

What are two protective factors that you would like to improve?

1	2
---	---

Describe how things might be different if you were able to improve these protective factors.

1
2

List *specific steps or actions* that might help to make these goals a reality.

1
2

Goal Planning

Setting Goals

Something I want to accomplish in the next week:

In the next month:

In the next year:

In five years:

Obstacles and Strategies

Obstacles to reaching my goals:

Things I will need to do to achieve my goals:

What I can begin doing tomorrow to work toward my goals:

Change-Plan Worksheet

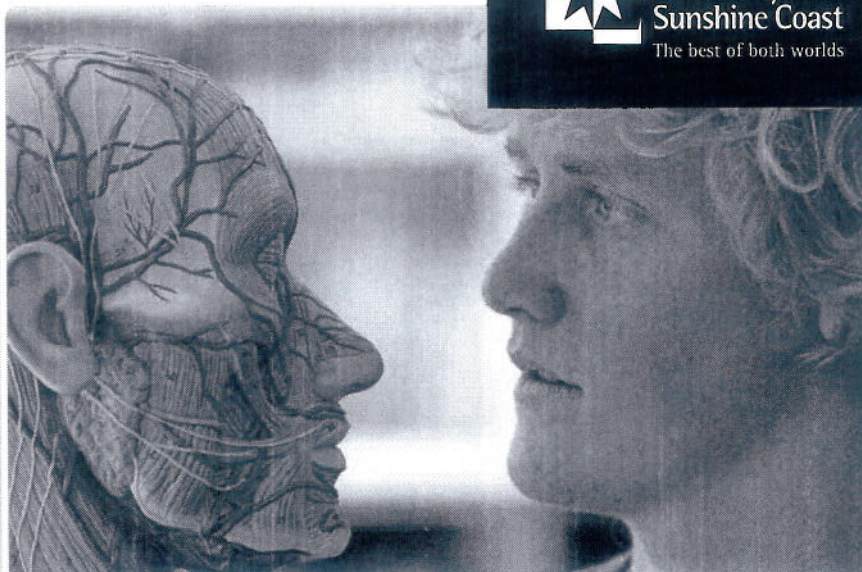
Changes I want to make:	
How important is it to me to make these changes? (1-10 scale)	
How confident am I that I can make these changes? (1-10 scale)	
The most important reasons I want to make these changes are:	
The steps I plan to take in changing are:	
How other people can help me:	
Person	Kind of help
I will know my plan is working when:	
Some things that could interfere with my plan are:	

Reframing your thinking

Mind-body connection

Our brains are capable of processing hundreds of separate pieces of information every second. This information is processed at multiple levels of consciousness by the brain, the outcome of which produces a thought.

It has been estimated that the human brain has between 50 000 and 65 000 thoughts per day. These thoughts are shaped and conditioned by our past experiences, our perspectives on life and our emotional states at the time.



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Thinking-emotion connection

Positive thoughts give rise to happy, contented emotions and negative thoughts result in sad and depressive emotions. These emotions then affect biological changes in the body. Basically, the quality of our thinking affects the emotions we experience and the state of our physical health.

Therefore, it stands to reason that if we think positive and healthy thoughts, then we'll feel healthy and be healthy. In fact, a considerable body of research suggests that the quality of an individual's thinking impacts on their levels of happiness, health, vitality and quality and length of life.



Automatic thoughts

Have you ever noticed that "little voice" in your head that always seems to be there, describing your world, creating ideas, forming opinions, making comments or even criticising your decisions, actions or outcomes? This running commentary or "mind chatter" is what we call self-talk or automatic thinking.

Automatic self-talk affects the way we experience life and is coloured by our perceptions, attitudes and beliefs. It affects the way we feel, the decisions we make, and the actions we take. This then affects the way we think about ourselves (self-image) and feel about ourselves (self esteem). Ultimately, thoughts are either empowering or limiting.

Positive vs negative thinking

The quality of our automatic self-talk can be viewed in two ways: Optimistic (+ve) or Pessimistic (-ve).

When our automatic self-talk is **optimistic** (positive, complimentary and kind) we generally have good self-esteem, a healthy self-image and we deal well with criticism, setback or disaster. Our problem solving is more effective and our levels of commitment and persistence to a task are higher—which is the foundation for most success.

However, problems arise when our self-talk takes on a **pessimistic** tone (negative, critical and self-abusive). This style of automatic self-talk affects us because we forecast doom and gloom for ourselves, and those around us.

Negative thinking causes us to stop trying and often sees us talk ourselves out of opportunities to succeed before we even start. This is called self-sabotage. Unfortunately, negative self-talk is so powerful it erodes our self-confidence and can lead to anxiety and depression. It also affects our self-esteem and ability to learn.

But do you know what? It's easy to change negative self-talk into positive self-talk. Why? Because negative self-talk is nothing more than a nasty little habit and, through deliberate change and rehearsal, new functional habits can replace old, dysfunctional ones.

Changing your self-talk

Deliberate, positive self-talk is the fastest and most effective ways to replace the negative "mind chatter" that limits us and makes us feel bad. Positive self-talk (in the form of short, positive statements) reprograms our thinking about ourselves, our abilities, and our situation, which flows on to improve our mood and general sense of well-being.

Thought monitoring

The first step to changing your automatic thoughts is to start taking particular notice of the themes and emotional tone of your self-talk. Listen out for your internal comments, challenge those comments that are negative, defeatist or abusive, and intentionally and deliberately reframe those thoughts so they are positive, supportive and encouraging.

Example: "This assignment is too big, I'll never get it finished".

Reframe: "If I relax and focus, break down the assignment into smaller bits and manage my time well, I'll finish by the deadline"; "Just making a start is one step closer to completion".

Example: "I've never done something this big before, what if I can't do it?"

Reframe: "I love a challenge. This assignment is simply a bigger version of my past successes—time to step up".

Example: "I've bombed the exam and now I'm going to fail this subject".

Reframe: "It's too early to tell yet, maybe I did better than I expected, let's wait and see".

It is important to note that positive self-talk is not self-delusion. Psychologically, it is known as Cognitive Reprogramming and acts to correct our faulty thinking. Faulty thinking is a bad habit that limits our chances for success and happiness.

"Silver Lining" thinking

This strategy comes quite naturally to positive, optimistic people. It simply involves seeing each event in our lives in a positive light—always looking for the good in people, situations and events—it's an attitude thing. By maintaining a positive attitude or perspective we inoculate ourselves from negative emotions and bounce back from hardship and disappointment easier. Most importantly, we develop resilience to emotional setback.

Event-thought-emotion-behaviour

Circumstantial events trigger your thoughts, which then produce your feelings, which may then determine your behaviours. Events do not directly produce your emotions. Rather, it's the thoughts that we have about the event that affects our emotions. These emotions then influence our behaviour. Therefore, appraising things that happen to us using a "Silver Lining Thinking" strategy is more likely to trigger a positive or neutral emotion rather than a negative, upsetting one.

Practice reframing negative thinking daily

When you notice a negative thought pattern occurring, consciously and deliberately interrupt that thought and replace it with a positive alternative. Good habits require practice, patience and commitment to become well established.

Positive affirmations

These are short, positive, empowering statements that make things happen. They are truisms about yourself or personal changes you'd like to make.

To make them work, positive affirmations should be:

- 1 Rehearsed regularly
- 2 Phrased positively
- 3 Framed in the present
- 4 Used in the first person – "I" statements
- 5 Focussed on self improvement, rather than compared to others
- 6 Descriptive, action words that generate emotion and feeling
- 7 Accurate, realistic and achievable
- 8 Aimed at developing personal traits, eg concentration, self control, patience etc
- 9 Focussed on eliciting specific behaviours, eg "I manage my time efficiently and effectively now"; "I'm fit and healthy and I really enjoy exercising on a daily basis"; "By setting regular goals and organizing my time I am becoming a more confident student".

Further information

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Mindfulness Exercises



Mindfulness Meditation

Find a place where you can sit quietly and undisturbed for a few moments. To begin, you might want to set a timer for about 10 minutes, but after some experience you should not be too concerned about the length of time you spend meditating.

Begin by bringing your attention to the present moment by noticing your breathing. Pay attention to your breath as it enters and then leaves your body. Before long, your mind will begin to wander, pulling you out of the present moment. That's ok. Notice your thoughts and feelings as if you are an outside observer watching what's happening in your brain. Take note, and allow yourself to return to your breathing.

Sometimes you might feel frustrated or bored. That's fine--these are just a few more feelings to notice. Your mind might start to plan an upcoming weekend, or worry about a responsibility. Notice where your thoughts are going, and accept what's happening.

Whenever you are able to, return your concentration to your breathing. Continue this process until your timer rings, or until you are ready to be done.



Body Scan

During the body scan exercise you will pay close attention to physical sensations throughout your body. The goal isn't to change or relax your body, but instead to notice and become more aware of it. Don't worry too much about how long you practice, but do move slowly.

Begin by paying attention to the sensations in your feet. Notice any sensations such as warmth, coolness, pressure, pain, or a breeze moving over your skin. Slowly move up your body--to your calves, thighs, pelvis, stomach, chest, back, shoulders, arms, hands, fingers, neck, and finally your head. Spend some time on each of these body parts, just noticing the sensations.

After you travel up your body, begin to move back down, through each body part, until you reach your feet again. Remember: move slowly, and just pay attention.



Mindful Eating

Choose a food you would like to practice with (preferably something you can hold in your hand without getting messy). Something as simple as a single raisin will work well. Move slowly through these steps, taking a moment to focus on each one.

Before you pick up your food, notice how it looks on the table in front of you. Notice its color, how the light reflects from its surface, and its size.

Mindfulness Exercises

Now, pick up the food. Notice the weight, and how the food feels against your skin. Roll the object between your fingers, or roll it in your hand, and notice its texture. Notice if it's smooth, rough, slick, soft, firm or if it has any other properties. Hold the food to your nose, and pay attention to its smell.

Next, place the food in your mouth, on your tongue, but don't eat it. Notice how it feels in your mouth. Does the texture feel the same as on your hand? What do you taste? Roll the food around in your mouth and pay attention to the feeling.

Finally, begin to slowly chew your food. Notice how your teeth sink into it, and how the texture is different inside. Pay close attention to the flavor, and how it spreads across your tongue. Notice how your body changes—does your mouth fill with saliva? Does your tongue feel hot or cold? Continue to chew your food, paying close attention to the many sensations as you finish.

Five Senses

Use this exercise to quickly ground yourself in the present when you only have a moment. The goal is to notice something that you are currently experiencing through each of your senses.

What are 5 things you can see? Look around you and notice 5 things you hadn't noticed before. Maybe a pattern on a wall, light reflecting from a surface, or a knick-knack in the corner of a room.

What are 4 things you can feel? Maybe you can feel the pressure of your feet on the floor, your shirt resting on your shoulders, or the temperature on your skin. Pick up an object and notice its texture.

What are 3 things you can hear? Notice all the background sounds you had been filtering out, such as an air-conditioning, birds chirping, or cars on a distant street.

What are 2 things you can smell? Maybe you can smell flowers, coffee, or freshly cut grass. It doesn't have to be a nice smell either: maybe there's an overflowing trash can or sewer.

What is 1 thing you can taste? Pop a piece of gum in your mouth, sip a drink, eat a snack if you have one, or simply notice how your mouth tastes. "Taste" the air to see how it feels on your tongue.

The numbers for each sense are only a guideline. Feel free to do more or less of each. Also, try this exercise while doing an activity like washing dishes, listening to music, or going for a walk.